

BEFORE 1800

JULY 1776

Declaration of Independence proclaims the “self-evident” truth that “all men are created equal.” But its main author, Thomas Jefferson, and many other signatories are enslavers.

JULY 1787

Congress passes the Northwest Ordinance forbidding slavery in the Northwest Territory –the future states of Ohio, Illinois, Michigan, and Wisconsin.

SEPTEMBER 1787

The new Constitution permits slavery.

SEPTEMBER 1789

In an amendment to the Constitution, an enslaved person counts as three-fifths of a white person when assessing Congressional representation.

FEBRUARY 1793

Fugitive Slave Act makes it easier for owners to recover escaped slaves. It results in free Black people being sold into slavery.

APRIL 1793

Introduction of cotton gin revolutionizes the cotton industry.



Cotton gin